Anthropology is the broad study of humankind around the world and throughout time. It is the study of the full scope of human diversity, past and present, and the application of that knowledge to help people of different backgrounds better understand one another. It is the study of people's everyday lives and communities with a deep understanding of behaviours, beliefs and institutions. From cultures, to artifacts, to languages, anthropology provides a unique and powerful way to look at human experience and at how people construct their own versions of what it means to be human. Anthropologists want to examine what people do and how they live and work together. Anthropologists ask compelling questions such as: How did we come to be human and who are our ancestors? Why do people look and act so differently throughout the world? What do we all have in common?

Anthropology seeks to find the generalities about human life while also explaining the differences. In considering diversity in space and time, anthropologists perceive the universal, the generalized, but also the particular, and the local, as they move back and forth between these two levels of inquiry and analysis in their work. Anthropologists examine the ways in which local communities interact with global forces.

The term *anthropology* comes from the two Greek words: *Anthropos*, meaning "human" and *logos*, meaning "to reason" (or to study). Literally, anthropology is the study of humanity.

The roots of anthropology lie in the eighteen and nineteenth centuries, as European's economic and social expansion increased contacts. It was not until mid-nineteenth century that sociology and anthropology emerged as distinct disciplines with individual identities. Even if these distinctions can sometimes be blurred, there are three main differences between sociology and anthropology: 1)

the **holistic** approach, 2) the **comparative** approach) and 3) the **ethnographic fieldwork**.

Holism means that the whole is greater than the sums of its parts. Human beings are what they are because of the mutual shaping of genes and culture and experiences that produce something new, yet something that cannot be reduced to the sums of his parts. That is, a society is not just a sum of the behaviours of its individuals but is a unique entity. Social living and cultural sharing are necessary for individual humans to develop what we recognize as human nature in its diversity. Anthropology, as a discipline, has the commitment to consider the full scope of human life, including culture, biology, history, and language, across space and time.

The **comparative** approach requires that anthropologists consider similarities and differences in a wide range of human societies before generalizing about human nature, human society and human history. It means considering the life experiences of people in every part of the world, comparing and contrasting cultural beliefs and practices to understand similarities and differences on a global scale.

Ethnographic fieldwork is at the heart of cultural anthropology. It means intensive stay in the field where the anthropologist is living and working with people on a daily basis, often for a year or more. Ethnographic fieldwork has the power of making what may at first seem very unfamiliar into something that ultimately will seem quite familiar, but also taking what has seemed very familiar and making it strange. To do so, anthropologists do not study people, they learn from them by putting themselves in their shoes. Through fieldwork, anthropologists look beyond the taken-for-granted, everyday experience of life to discover the complex systems of power and meaning.

Ultimately, through a holistic approach, intensive ethnographic fieldwork and cross-cultural comparison, anthropologists seek to help people better understand one and another and the way the world works.

Thinking like an Anthropologist

Believe it or not, but we all employ the skills of an anthropologist on a daily basis. Every time you walk in a room, and try to figure out how to fit in. What are you supposed to do? What are the rules? What are the power dynamics?

Anthropology provides a toolkit for re-evaluating and critiquing many core ideas and values you have probably been taught as being “true”, “right”, “normal” or “natural”.

If you've been lucky to travel a little bit in other countries, sometimes you must have been in contact with and confronted by the fact that people were saying or doing things you didn't understand or felt weird or you felt uncomfortable. Thinking like an anthropologist will allow you to put that in perspective and try to understand why people do the things they do and why the people say the things they say?

Fieldwork skills and strategies can help you navigate the many unfamiliar or cross-cultural experiences you will encounter at work or school, in your community, or in your family. And hopefully you will see how key fieldwork strategies can help you become a more engaged and responsible citizen of the world.

Anthropology is traditionally divided in four main subdisciplines:

- Physical Anthropology
- Archeology

- Linguistic Anthropology
- Sociocultural Anthropology

Table of the 4 subdisciplines of Anthropology

Physical Anthropology

- Origin of Humans
- Theory of Evolution
- Genetic Inheritances
- Physical Adaptations
- Paleoanthropology/ Primatology

Archeology

- Investigation of the human past
- Excavation and analysis of material remains (artefacts)
- Reconstruction of our ancestors' lives and behaviors

Linguistic Anthropology

- Study of human language
- Reflect of people's ideas and experiences
- Language: the most distinctive feature of being human
- Sociolinguistic

Sociocultural Anthropology

- Definition and aspects of culture
- Study of people's everyday lives and their communities
    - Behaviors
    - Beliefs
    - Institutions
- Participant observation/Ethnography

Physical Anthropology

Physical, or biological, anthropology is the study of human biology and the origin of humans. It focuses on human beings as living organisms and what makes us different from or similar to other living things. Physical anthropology relies on the study of biological evolutions of the human species as well as primates, paying

attention not only to human origins but also to the patterns of biological variation in populations. Traditionally, physical anthropologists have relied on the theory of evolution and genetic inheritance to explain physical variations. First physical anthropologies have been known for having helped the development of racial categories and theories on the basis of skin colour, hair and body types that have supported racism. Yet, support for non-racial understandings of human populations and debunking of racial stereotypes also have a long history in North America.

Primatology and paleoanthropology are included in physical anthropology.

Archeology

Archeology is the study of the human past through the excavation, retrieval and analysis of material remains. It can include bodily remains (which can certainly give a great deal of information about how they lived and died), but also the remains of the things they built, produced, and made use of (material artifacts). In other words, archeologists attempt to find and study all the traces that human groups have left behind – of themselves and their activities – and they seek to understand the way they lived. Theses traces are the only source of information about human societies before writing began (around 5,500 years ago) and help the reconstruction of our ancestors' lives and behaviors

Linguistic Anthropology

Linguistic anthropology is the study and analysis of human communication, most especially of human language. Language is one of the most distinctive features of being human. Language is the key to our ability to learn and share culture from generation to

generation, to cooperate in groups, and to adapt to our environment.

Some linguists attempt to reconstruct the earlier languages from which our present languages have evolved. Others study modern languages in order to learn how they encode the range of human experiences and reveal the different social groups within a society. More recently, linguistic anthropologists have worked with endangered languages.

Cultural Anthropology

Cultural anthropology, also called sociocultural anthropology, is the study of people's everyday lives and their communities, with a particular attention on behaviors, beliefs and institutions. Cultural anthropologists study culture, describing, analyzing, and explaining social and cultural similarities and differences. Cultural anthropologists tend to specialize in one domain of human cultural activities or another. Many cultural anthropologists study language, music, dance, art, religion, social and political organizations. Transcending racism in early anthropological studies, modern cultural anthropologists are concerned with studying all cultures, including their own, as they do research in rural and urban settings, at home and abroad. Labels as *civilized* and *primitive* are rejected since in addition to being offensive, they do not make sense of the everyday realities and complexities of human life.

Cultural anthropology is at the core of this course, so is culture which we will now have a look at. The better we understand culture, the close we can come to understanding what it means to be human.

Culture lies at the hearth of sociocultural anthropology. To better understand human experience, anthropologists use the concept of

culture, and they approach fieldwork through an ethnographic approach.

Culture is a system. It is a cognitive map of knowledge, beliefs, patterns of behaviours, artifacts, and institutions that are created, learned, and shared by a group of people. Culture includes shared norms, values, symbols, material objects as well as structures of power – including the media, education, religion, and politics – in which our understanding of the world is shaped, reinforced, and challenged.

The formal definition of culture that we will be using in the course is as follows:

Culture is the learned and shared knowledge that people use to generate behaviour and interpret experience *(McCurdy, Shandy and Spradley, 2012)*.

Let's tackle this complex, yet simple definition.

Characteristics and Attributes of Culture

Culture is the learned and shared knowledge that people use to generate behaviour and interpret experience.

Anthropologists argue that culture is learned and therefore, it is taught. It is not biologically inherited.

Many colourful houses in an urban slum neighbourhood (also called barrio) of Mexico City

Via Latin American Countries

Luxurious houses in Orange County California

Via Everything-PR.com

Imagine being raised in a Mexican barrio (urban neighbourhood) or in Orange County (one of the wealthiest parts of California). Would you learn and share the same cultural knowledge? Would you behave the same?

All humans are equally capable of learning a culture when they are exposed to it. Culture is learned through a process called ***enculturation***.

Two kinds of Enculturation

There are two kinds of enculturation: formal and informal.

Formal enculturation

Formal enculturation is done through school and education like you are doing today, will be doing throughout this semester as well as your K-12 schooling. In school, you are being formally put in contact with cultural knowledge through instruction.

Information enculturation

Informal enculturation is largely how we learn a culture. It is through informal processes of enculturation that are mostly unconscious that we "absorb" from the culture we are surrounded by. We learn it from family, friends, and even from media, such as social media, television programming, and music.

All of these forms of informal enculturation are ways in which you are taking in cultural knowledge. Therefore, you learn culture.

Processes of enculturation, whether formal or informal, shape how we behave and interpret the world around us from our early days. They also impact what we eat and how we eat as we can see in this example:

In most parts of North America, parents are encouraged to feed babies and kids with milk. In contrast, for many people in China , milk (especially cow milk) is considered undrinkable.

North American infant being fed with a bottle of milk

Via www.psychologytoday.com

Asian infant being fed non-milk food with a spoon

Via beabausa.com

Reflect on how having been raised in a culture where milk is considered undrinkable (partly because cows are considered a sacred animal) would change your whole worldview.

Culture is the learned and ***shared knowledge*** that people use to generate behaviour and interpret experience.

Culture is shared knowledge. Culture is shared as a result of living as a member of a group, a community, a culture, a microculture. It is

shared by different groups, whether they are small or large, to establish patterns of behaviour that allows us to live in communities. We learn to speak from hearing our parents and siblings. We learn to interact from all the interactions we witness around us. We often learn by imitating others.

A man helping a young boy use a hammer and nails

Via www.everythingfordads.com

Three school-aged kids learning about nature with their teacher

Via resilienteducator.com

Cultural knowledge is ***not*** personal knowledge. It is mentally organized in the same way, but personal knowledge is not always shared.

However, just because culture is shared, does not mean it is not contested. Culture is constantly evolving because culture is never static. It is always changing. It is reworked and negotiated within the members of a group or community. Culture is adapted as it is passed from from a person to another through the process of enculturation. As time passes, people challenge and debates past cultural practices causing culture to evolve.

For example, the learned and shared cultural knowledge around fishing and fishing techniques have changed over time.

Culture is the learned and shared knowledge that people use to ***generate behaviour*** and interpret experience.

Cultural knowledge generates behaviour.

It also impacts how we act and behave. People living in various parts of the world look and behave in dramatically different ways.

Culture has an impact and affects how we dress, such as what is considered “normal” within the culture, a specific situation, and even within a specific religion.

Culture has an impact on how we eat and what we eat. Whether we eat with a stick, directly with your hands, or with a fork and knife (like we do here in North America).

We are more familiar with our culture’s foods while in other cultures and in other countries they are eating things radically different from us.

For example, eating soup for breakfast is common in Vietnam and Thailand. Forget eggs and bacon and embrace eating hot soup for breakfast!

Traditional English breakfast
From Major Thierno

Think about how it would feel "strange" or "awkward" to eat eggs and bacon or cereal for someone who has been eating soup for breakfast their whole life.

Culture influences what we eat. It also influences how food is produced and how the food that ends up on our table is grown. (More information about subsistence strategies will be provided in the module on Ecology and Subsistence)

Culture has impact on how we dance, how we party - Whether you're more into head banging, break dancing or gumboots (dancing while wearing rubber boots).

While cultural knowledge has a huge impact on how we party and dance, it also has a great impact on how we pray and for whom we pray.

Culture is the learned and shared knowledge that people use to generate behaviour and ***interpret experience***.

Cultural knowledge helps us interpret experience. To interpret refers to attaching meaning to something. It is a synonym of decoding.

Cultures are largely composed of and transmitted by symbols. Human beings act based on the meaning attached to objects and behaviours. The meanings of such things are derived from and arise out of the social interaction that one has with others. People who live in the same community tend to learn similar things. They interpret their experience similarly, or at least within a fairly restricted range, and they tend to behave similarly, again within a range of what is considered by others with whom they interact to be the appropriate behaviour. Cultural meaning is passed along and modified through an interpretive process used by people when dealing with objects and behaviours they encounter throughout their daily life.

Therefore, when we say that my culture is different from yours, what we're really saying is that I've learned things differently than you - I have interpreted things and experiences differently and as a result I behave differently.

In North America, and most parts of Europe, rats are considered undesirable animals (pests), while in other countries, rats are considered sacred and would not be eaten or killed. Rats, like cows,

are seen as sacred in Indian worship. For example, the Hindu elephant headed God, Ganesh, is always accompanied by rats whenever he travels. Therefore, in India, no worship is complete without an offering to Ganesh and its companions, the rats.

A child feeding and caring for rats in a Rat Temple in India
Via www.holidaytravel.co

In India, some people also devote worship to cows as sacred animals. The cow is regarded by Hindus as a maternal figure and has had a long-standing central role in India's religious rituals.

Think about growing up in a culture where cows and rats are viewed as sacred, how would you react to people outside your culture eating cows and rats?

There are two basic kinds of culture that can be explained using an iceberg as an analogy: **explicit** culture and **tacit** culture.

Explicit culture is the small part above the water that we can easily see. Tacit culture is the big chunk of ice beneath the surface, under the water and hidden from view.

Explicit culture

Explicit culture is the cultural knowledge that people are consciously aware of and can talk about. It is a level of knowledge that people can communicate about with relative ease. In order words, it is what comes easily to mind when you talk about your own culture or others' culture. It is often about food, music, tales, traditions, dance, religion, language and dialects and so on.

Tacit culture

Tacit culture, also called implicit culture, is cultural knowledge that is outside our awareness. Implicit culture is not coded in words, it is unconscious. For example, think of a queue at the bus stop. There is no signage on the sidewalk that explicitly tells you to wait behind the people that were already there, or any information on how close you should stand behind the person in front of you. You have probably learned these rules via by previously observing people at a bus stop.

Anthropologists are particularly interested in understanding implicit culture. The example of implicit culture that follows shows how the physical distance you unconsciously assume when you speak to others is culturally learned but not consciously defined. It also demonstrates how discomfort can arise when implicit cultural knowledge is not completely mastered.

Edward Hall’s Speaking Distances

Edward Hall is considered to be a pioneer of the study of implicit culture. His observations of human interactions led him to propose four speaking distances: 1) intimate; 2) personal; 3) social; and 4) public.

He noticed that in casual speech, most South Americans stand closer to one another than do North Americans. Neither group is aware of the difference, which can lead to discomfort when they try to interact with each other. It is the feeling that you have when someone is "in your personal bubble” (otherwise known as that feeling you have when a person is too close to you or is speaking too close from your face).

Think about when you are at home with family members or when you are with your lover. If you pay attention, you will realize that you tend to lean forward and get closer to the people you are more comfortable with. Would you adopt the same posture and the same speaking distance if you were talking with your instructor that you met at the grocery store? Most likely not!

We discussed what culture *is* so far. Let's move to what culture *is not*.

1. ***Culture is not the same as civilization***. Civilization refers to a complex society supported by intensive food production organized around large urban centres providing administrative, commercial, artistic and religious leadership.
2. Culture **is not** the same as society

   Culture is not the same as a society. Although we often use those terms interchangeably in loose talk, the relationship between society and culture is that a society, by means of

interactions among its members, creates and perpetuates a culture.

3. Culture **is not** the same as being refined or sophisticated

   Culture is not the same as being refined or sophisticated. You do have a culture, everyone does, even though you don't know the names of all famous French oil painters or appreciate Opera.

4. Culture **is not** the explanation for everything people do

   Culture is not the explanation for everything people do. "It's culture that made them do it!" Culture helps us understand where behaviour comes from, but it does not explain them all, like criminal or deviant behaviours. Anthropology does not claim that culture offers a complete explanation of all human behaviour. People can act with, around, and against their own culture.

5. Culture **is not** behaviour

   Culture is not behaviour. Behaviours are guided by our culture. It is not a collection of behaviours.

6. Culture **is not** just food customs, musical traditions, and colorful costumes

   Culture is not just food, customs, musical traditions or colourful costumes. Yes, culture is about food customs, musical traditions, and colorful costumes, but it is not only about these aspects of explicit culture.

7. Culture **is not** complete agreement or consensus

> ***Culture is not complete agreement or consensus***. We can share the same culture, but have different views on religion, politics, or sport. What culture provides is a language for discussion.

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Ethnography is the unique strategy employed by sociocultural anthropologists to discover and describe a particular culture. Chemists conduct experiments in laboratories, economics analyse financial trends, demographers crunch census data, historians pull over records and library archives, sociologists, economists, and political scientists analyze trends, quantifiable data, official organizational and national policies. Anthropologists conduct ethnographies.

Ethnography is the process of discovering and describing a particular culture *(McCurdy, Shandy and Spradley, 2012).*

When anthropologists seek to study a group's culture, they look for the **insider's viewpoint**. The goal in mind is that they view the actions and knowledge of a group through the eyes of its members. In other words, they aim to become a part of the world they seek to understand.

To get to the insider's viewpoint, anthropologists conduct fieldwork.

Fieldwork

Fieldwork is the process of immersing oneself in as many aspects of the daily cultural lives of people in order to study their behaviours and interactions. Fieldwork is how anthropologists gather data. Anthropologists conduct ethnographies often by living among the people whose culture they wish to study, learning their language, asking questions, and observing their behaviours. They move into a community, occupy a house, watch people's daily routines, attend rituals, and spent hours interviewing informants. In the fieldwork process, anthropologists eventually look at kinship, language, religion, politics, and economic systems, which allows them to build a picture of the society.

Nearly any setting or location can become "the field": a village along the Nile River in Egypt, a large corporate office in Singapore, a small neighborhood café in Montreal, or even a social networking site like Facebook.

Fieldwork strategies and Methods

There are two main strategies that anthropologists use when doing fieldwork.

Detached observation is a research approach in which investigators observe human behaviour and create their own categories and theories to describe and explain it. Interactions with the participants or the subjects is prohibited or not desirable.

Anthropologists are trained to pay close attention to everything that happens around them when in the field, whether it is part of daily routine such as cooking or part of major events such as an annual religious ceremony. They observe how people interact with one another, how the environment affects people, and how people affect the environment.

Participant observation is a research approach in which investigators learn about people by participating in their daily activities, walking in their shoes, seeing through their eyes. It is the hallmark method of ethnographic field research in anthropology.

Ethnography: Polish anthropologist, Bronislaw Malinowski (1884-1942), pioneer of the method of participant observation, noted is an important tool by which to grasp the native's point of view, his relation to life, to realize his vision of his world. *Bronislaw Malinowski, Argonauts of the Western Pacific: An Account of Native Enterprise and Adventure in the Archipelagoes of Melanesian New Guinea (London: Kegan Paul, 1922), 25.*

It is one thing to be observing the way people are living and another thing to translate that experience into words. Anthropology often consists of writing ethnography. To do so, it is essential for anthropologists to rigorously document their observations, usually be writing field notes, and recording their feelings and perceptions of a personal journal. These fieldwork notes will be used for writing ethnography.

Writing ethnography involves the difficult task of representing one system of cultural knowledge to an audience belonging to another cultural tradition. It involves translating foreign cultures into Canadian English word categories in order to understand other cultural practices from our Canadian point-of-view. Most of the required readings are excerpts of longer written ethnographies.

It is important to note that traditionally, anthropologists have written about other cultures from the lens of a Euro-American, colonial society (often comparing other cultures to the [wrongful] superiority of Euro-American society) for consumption by others within Euro-American society. This has started to change within the discipline thanks to collaboration and recognition of Indigenous anthropologists and community members as the experts in analysing their culture. Along with the recognition of Indigenous ways of knowing as equal to scientific ways of knowing.

Naming those we work with

While seeking for the insider's viewpoint, anthropologists look for informants. Informants are different from subjects or respondents.

Subjects are people who are observed when experimental social or behavioural research is conducted. The term probably originates from the phrase “subjects of experiments” and is associated with hypothesis testing and the creation of analytical terms.

Respondents are people who respond to survey questionnaires. Researchers will design the questionnaire to test a hypothesis (they are aware of what they want to know) with a defined set of specific questions (they ask those they study to “respond” to the questions).

These approaches of studying subjects and of respondents completing questionnaires differ from ethnography. Ethnographers strive to elicit the insiders’, the "local", or the "folk" perspective. As much as possible, anthropologists avoid leading people to respond to categories constructed by the investigator.

Informants are people who teach anthropologists, who teach ethnographers about their own culture. We learn about their cultural knowledge. Anthropologists do not study informants; they work with them. They learn from them.

Going back to the example of settings or location of fieldwork, informants from a village along the Nile River in Egypt could be the village elders, informants from a large corporate office in Singapore could be the administrative staffs, the informants of a small neighborhood café in Montreal could the baristas or the regular customers.

Naïve realism asserts that humans have a natural tendency to believe that the world they see is exactly the world as it exists—that they objectively perceive reality, and anyone who disagrees with them is either irrational, biased, or simply a contrarian.

There are three key moments of ethnographical fieldwork.

- Preparation prior to entering the field
- On the field
- Leaving the field

Preparation prior to entering the field

- Learn about what (and who) you want to study before entering the field. Read everything you can find about your research site and particular issue you will examine.
- Learn the language (or not?): The ability to speak the local language eliminates the need to work through interpreters and

allows us to participate in the community’s everyday activities and conversations, which reflect local culture.
- Obtain ethics approval and, if needed, approval from the appropriate government agencies.
- Gender considerations and ethics approval.
- Lout for possible contacts beforehand through existing networks.
- Have your anthropologist's toolkit ready! Backpack, notebook, pens, camera, voice recorder (and batteries!), maps, cell phone, dictionary, ID and little gifts.

On the field

- Keep an open-minded attitude: leaving judgments and preconceptions aside.
- Developing relationships, trust, and rapport. Be known and recognized to be accepted. Moving from the "outsider" to " insider" and having been seen as a threatening presence.
- Being supportive and useful.
- Use the snow-ball strategy and word-of-mouth to recruit informants.
- Observe and listen carefully. Make sure to be always observing when in the field!
- Take detailed field notes or logbooks.

Leaving the field

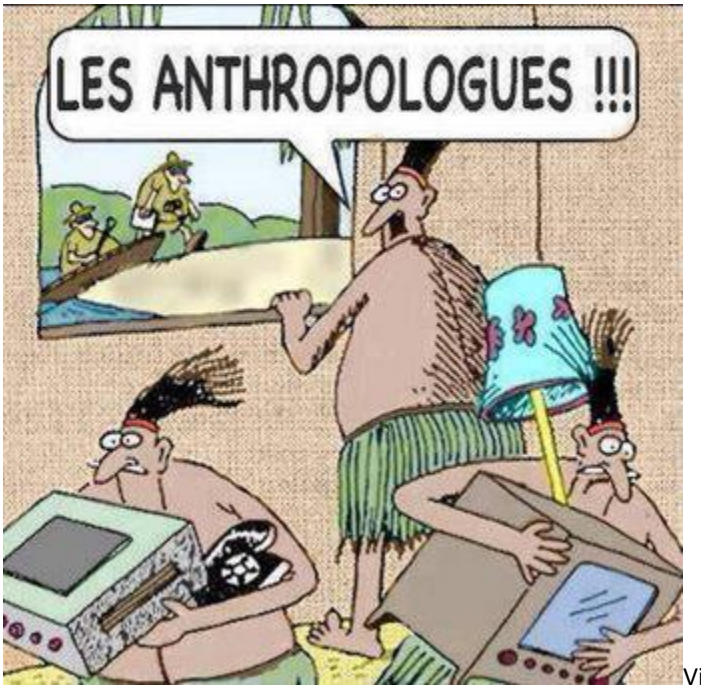
- Leaving the field can be more or less easy due to emotional and physical involvement.
- Stay in touch with your informants and keep them informed.

- Moving from the field to data analysing and ethnographical writing.

Two sources of Ethnographic Bias

There are two sources of ethnographic bias. Most anthropologists will be confronted by these two ethnographic biases when doing fieldwork.

Naive Realism



Via twitter.com

Naïve Realism is the unconscious belief that reality is much the same for everybody no matter what their culture.

Naïve realism is a common perspective held by all people. It creates a problem for ethnographers because they are likely to project their cultural perspective on that of their informants. On the other hand, naïve realism in informants is advantageous because the ethnographer seeks to understand the informants' perception of the world.

Naïve realism asserts that humans have a natural tendency to believe that the world they see is exactly the world as it exists - that they *objectively* perceive reality, and anyone who disagrees with them is either irrational or biased.

Ethnocentrism

Ethnocentrism is the belief and feeling that one's own culture is best.

Development of the anthropological perspective through fieldwork, in which we investigate the beliefs and practices of other cultures, enables us to perceive our own cultural activities in a new light. Even the most familiar aspects of our lives may then appear exotic, bizarre, or strange when viewed through the lenses of anthropology. Through this cross-cultural training, anthropology offers the opportunity to unlock our ability to imagine, see, and analyse the incredible diversity of human culture. It also enables us to avoid the tendencies of ethnocentrism, in which we often view our own cultural practices as "normal" and against which we are inclined to judge the cultural beliefs and practices of others. Anthropologists must learn to recognize and control their own ethnocentrism because expressing judgments about what an informant says gets in the way when eliciting cultural content.

Informants often express ethnocentric feelings as Barbadians did in George Gmelch's article: "Nice Girls Don't Talk to Rastas: Status and Sensibilities in a Caribbean Village." For them, the American student's association with a Rasta was morally reprehensible.

Ethnocentrism and naive realism can lead to cultural shock and cross-cultural misunderstanding.

Culture shock

Culture shock is a form of anxiety that results from an inability to predict the behaviour of others or to act appropriately in cross-cultural situations.

Culture shock is not so much a form of bias as it is an impediment to ethnographic research. A sense of disorientation caused by the overwhelmingly new and unfamiliar people and experiences encountered every day. When shock sets in, ethnographers are likely to withdraw. Over time, the disorientation may fade as the unfamiliar becomes familiar. But then, many anthropologists feel cultural shock again when returning home, where their new perspective causes previously familiar people and customs to seem very strange.

Have you ever felt culture shock when traveling to a different country or just different scenery?

Cross-cultural misunderstanding

Cross-cultural misunderstanding occurs when people with different cultural knowledge attempt to communicate with each other. Cultural values sometimes conflict when people from different cultural groups interact together. We can misunderstand each other and react in ways that can hinder rapprochements. Oftentimes, we are not aware that culture is acting upon us. Sometimes, we are not even aware that we have cultural values or assumptions that are different from "others". Much of the ethnographic research conducted by anthropologists is aimed at reducing cross-cultural misunderstanding by translating cultural differences from one culture to another.